effectively put an end to this practice in the future too. [This Bill was eventually passed in 1996.]

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'There are many gangsters here who trade in hashish, smack and other drugs,' observed the warden during a meeting. 'The move is to isolate these prisoners. Here they will not be allowed to avail of any prison benefits. No *mulaqaat* for these inmates – they will not be allowed any visitors, nor will they be permitted any food or eatables from outside. No canteen items, either – like biscuits, cigarettes, nail polish and such. Their rooms will have no ceiling fans. And, most important, they will be under constant vigilance.'

The move had the desired effect on the violators. Knowing how serious the new regime was about the step, a number of prisoner-addicts requested the new IG to provide them medical treatment.

Exemplary punishment was meted out to a member of the staff, namely, warder Raj Singh, who was an addict himself and who peddled drugs in jail to support his addiction. He was dismissed from service and also had to serve time in prison.

'If we had to convince the inmates of our positive intentions, then we had to first gain their trust and confidence,' explains the superintendent of Jail 2. 'The opportunity came on 2 August [1993], on the festival of Raksha Bandhan. This is a deeply emotive occasion between brothers and sisters (an occasion when sisters tie colourful *rakhis* on the wrists of their brothers as a token of the love that binds them together; brothers, in turn, are thus symbolically bound to love, honour and protect their sisters) and this was a good opportunity for us to contact the prisoners at the emotional level. We decided that, on Raksha Bandhan day, we would permit the prisoners' sisters to tie *rakhis* on their brothers' wrists within the prison doors. We of course planned our security arrangements in meticulous detail. We communicated this to the prisoners. Tears welled up in their eyes when they reassured us that they would do nothing that would force us to hang our heads in shame. How could they, they asked, when it was all being done for their sake? On 2 August, amidst very emotional scenes, brothers vowed to their sisters that they would give up their wrong ways. No effort on our part could have achieved as much as this occasion did. We get repeated requests from a number of inmates to be shown the video tapes and the albums again and again. This charges them up emotionally.'

Similarly, all festive occasions of the various communities that make up the composite culture of India were celebrated. The response of the inmates belonging to diverse faiths to, and their participation in, the festivities during Guru Purv, Diwali, Christmas, Eid and New Year were total and wholesome.

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* This is a very popular bhajan from V. Shantaram's 1957 film *Do Aankhen Baraah Haath*. The theme of this film was the reform of hardened prisoners. The bhajan has been sung by Lata Mangeshkar and by a chorus in two separate versions. The soulful lyrics have been penned by Bharat Vyas and the inspiring music has been composed by Vasant Desai.